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The recipe for great text

Great text = (What + So What + What Next) ÷ User state of mind (USoM)

This formula is the spine of our microcopy. Every asset and string should answer three questions:

What

What is happening on this screen or control?

This is the factual layer: the object, action, or state. It shows the user where they are and what this part of the product is for.

- On **pages**, the What is the page title and key labels.
- In **dialogs**, it is the header (for example, **Ready to remove access for...?**).
- In **toasts and errors**, it is the first line (for example, **Connection to AWS failed.**).

If the What is vague, everything else collapses. Aim for **one clear, concrete idea** per string.

So What

Why does this matter right now? What's the impact or benefit?

This is the meaning layer. It connects the feature to an outcome the user cares about.

- On **pages**, So What usually lives in the subheader:
Define administrator roles so that teams get the right access to cloud assets.
- In **errors**, So What explains the consequence:
New users won't be able to sign in until the connection is fixed.

So What turns features into reasons. It reduces anxiety (**What happens if I click this?**) and promotes the right choice without selling or hyping.

What Next

What is the next safe, useful step?

This is the action layer and it lives mainly in buttons and links.

- **Primary CTA:** one clear **verb + object** (for example, **Save changes**, **Reconnect account**, **Add cloud environment**).
- Avoid **Yes/No**, **OK/Cancel**. The button should be self-contained and scannable out of context.

When What, So What, and What Next are all present, the user can understand, decide, and act without rereading or scanning the whole page.

User state of mind (USoM)

USoM = Intent + Emotion + Environment.

Before you write, quickly note:

- **Intent** – What is the user trying to achieve on this screen?
 - Example: *Invite a contractor with limited access for a short project.*
- **Emotion** – How are they likely to feel right now? Confident, rushed, blocked, worried about breaking something?
 - Example: *Nervous about removing access in case they lock someone out.*
- **Environment** – Where and how are they using this? Laptop at a desk, mobile on the go, shared SOC monitor, noisy office?
 - Example: *Admin in a SOC, scanning alerts quickly on a large dashboard.*

USoM doesn't belong in the UI, but it should shape the tone and density of the text:

- If intent is **high-risk** and emotion is **anxious**, be more explicit about consequences and safe exits.
- If intent is **exploratory** and emotion is **curious**, offer gentle guidance and optional links instead of warnings.
- If the environment is **noisy or constrained**, prioritize short strings, clear headings, and verbs that can be understood at a glance.

USoM check (pre-flight)

Before writing, note the user's **Intent**, **Emotion**, and **Environment** (USoM). Write to where the user is in the flow.

Why this matters

USoM keeps copy empathetic and decisive. When intent is clear and emotion is considered,

Then, **What → So What → What Next** falls into place, which lowers cognitive load, and helps users finish tasks without re-reading.

Voice & Tone

Voice VS. Tone

CyberArk has one consistent **voice** across products and touchpoints, like a person. The voice reflects who we are and does not change.

Our **tone** shifts with the situation. Tone is how that voice sounds in a given context: calm, instructive, reassuring, or gently motivational. Tone is set by the user's state of mind (USoM) and by the asset type (for example, in-product UI, deep technical docs, landing pages, or support content).

CyberArk has one voice everywhere. It is direct, clear, transparent, and simple. That voice stays the same across products and channels.

Tone is how that voice adapts to a situation. It changes with the user's state of mind and the context: onboarding, day-to-day work, minor friction, or high-stress incidents. Tone can be more instructive, more reassuring, or occasionally more motivational or supportive, but it always sounds like CyberArk.

- **Voice (always on):** Direct • Clear & precise • Transparent (single meaning) • Simple language • We make the complex simple.
- **Tone (adapts by context):** Conversational • Approachable • Reassuring • Helpful • Supportive.
- **Reading level:** aim ~6th–8th grade; short sentences; concrete verbs.
- **Avoid filler/hype:** no **easy, simply, just**. **Avoid “please”**; be respectful without being sycophantic.

Tone spectrum by context

Tone	Attitude	How often
Motivational	Positive and encouraging	Rarely
Helpful	Polite and respectful	Occasionally
Instructive	Neutral and direct	Often
Reassuring	Professional and reliable	Occasionally
Supportive	Concerned and empathetic	Rarely

Use **Instructive** as the default for most product copy. Shift toward **Helpful** or **Reassuring** when users are blocked or anxious. Reserve **Motivational** and **Supportive** tones for rare, high-touch moments where users need extra encouragement or care (for example, complex setup flows or serious incident messaging).

Flow taxonomy (where patterns apply)

Content appears in the following formats: **Flow** → **Page** → **Card** → **Dialog** → **Alert/Toast**. This current guide includes these as well as **Empty**, **Errors**, **Controls**, and **Wizards**. Apply the same grammar at each smaller unit.

Quick reference

- **Pages:** Title = What. Subheader = So What (verb-led). CTA = What Next.
- **Dialogs:** Title = Verb. Body = What's at stake. CTA = same verb.
- **Empty/Zero/No-results:** Clear state + recovery or next step.
- **Errors:** Specific problem. Body **impact + fix**. CTA/link **Do it** or **Take me there**.
- **Labels are nouns. Descriptions are verbs.**
- **Use breadcrumbs** to keep titles short.
- **No “click on [Button]”.** Prefer **Take me there / Do it / Learn more**.
- **USoM check** before you write: Intent • Emotion • Environment.
- **Numerals 1–9 are OK in UI** when scannability or space benefits (docs may differ).
- **“One or more”** (never “file(s)”, “option(s)”).
- For two distinct outcomes, use: **You can do one of the following:** then bullets: **To do x ... / To do y, ...**

ASSET BREAKDOWN: How to use this section

Ad-lib cues

Anything in **(parentheses)** is for your head only (don't print). Anything in **[brackets]** is a slot to fill. This format will give us a unified cadence across all assets and touchpoints.

A. Pages — titles & subheaders

Purpose

Pages orient the user and define scope. They primarily answer **What**, then **So what**.

Page title (What)

Pattern:

[Adjective] [Noun]

(What is this place?)

Rules

- If breadcrumbs exist, keep the title short.

- If no breadcrumbs exist, scope the title explicitly.
- Avoid verbs for persistent pages.
- Avoid onboarding language outside first-time flows.

Examples

- **Authentication settings**
- **Discover identity landscape**
- **Secure access management settings**

Page subheader (So what)

Pattern:

(This is where you can) **[verb] [object]** so that **[benefit / outcome]**.

(Optional) (Keep in mind) **[scope or impact statement]**.

Rules

- Verb-led.
- The *so that* clause is required.
- Focus on outcomes, not features.
- Second sentence is optional and used for scope.

Examples

- **Define administrator roles so that teams get the right access to cloud assets.**
These changes apply across your organization.

CTAs (What next)

Pattern:

[Verb] [object]

Rules

- Avoid Yes / No.
- Match the action implied by the page.

B. Dialogs — confirmations & critical actions

Purpose

Dialogs interrupt flow to confirm intent or prevent loss. They answer **What decision**, **So what happens**, and **What next**.

Dialog title (What)

Pattern:

[Question framing the decision]?

(What choice is the user making?)

Rules

- Always a question.
- No system jargon.

Dialog body (So what)

Pattern:

(If you do) **[consequence of proceeding]**.

Rules

- State outcome plainly.
- No implementation detail.

CTAs (What next)

Primary CTA pattern:

[Action that proceeds]

Secondary CTA pattern:

[Action that safely backs out]

Rules

- CTAs must mirror outcomes.
- Ampersand allowed when one action triggers two results.

Examples

- **Leave this wizard?**
If you do, your changes won't be saved.
Not now / Leave
 - **Save and close?**
If you leave now, we'll save your progress so you can finish this wizard later.
Save & close / Continue
-

C. Empty, zero, and no-result states

Purpose

These states explain absence and offer recovery. They reduce uncertainty and keep users moving.

Header (What)

Pattern:

[What's missing or didn't match]

Rules

- Neutral, factual.
- No blame.

Body (So what)

Pattern:

(We couldn't) **[find / show / load]** **[object]**.

(Optional) (This usually means) **[reason or reassurance]**.

Rules

- Use past tense for searches.

- Do not explain permissions here.

CTA (What next)

Pattern:

[Most likely recovery action]

Examples

- **No secrets to present yet**
Run a scan on your AWS secret store to view your secrets.
Add secret store
 - **No results to show**
Clear the filters and try again.
Clear filters / Refresh
-

D. System availability & status states

Purpose

These states explain failure or unavailability calmly and clearly.

Header (What)

Pattern:

[System state or problem]

Body (So what)

Pattern:

(This means) **[plain explanation]**.

(Optional reassurance) **[what's okay / what's next]**.

CTA (What next)

Pattern:

[Best recovery path]

Examples

- **We can't find the page you're looking for**
Please check the address or go back to where you were.
Go back / Take me home
 - **You don't have permission(s) to view this page**
Please contact your administrator to request access.
Contact administrator
 - **Down for maintenance**
We'll be back soon.
Go back
-

E. Errors, toasts & banners

Purpose

Communicate failures, confirmations, or non-obvious system behavior.

Inline error (What)

Pattern:

[What's missing or invalid]

Rules

- Short.
- Field-level only.

Example

- **Required field**

Toast (So what)

Pattern:

[What just happened]

Rules

- Past tense.
- Use only when success isn't visually obvious.

Example

- **Command copied to clipboard**

Banner / note (So what + What next)

Pattern:

[Important system behavior]. *(Optional)* **[What the user needs to do].**

Example

- *Language and time zone changes are automatically saved, but you need to sign out and sign back in to update.*
-

F. Controls (toggles, settings, steppers)

Purpose

Controls enable, disable, or configure behavior. They answer **What changes** and often **So what**.

Control label (What)

Pattern:

[Verb] [object]

Rules

- Verb-led fragment.
- No period.

- No scope or timing.

Helper text / tooltip (So what)

Pattern:

(This) **[sets / affects] [scope]**. (Optional) (You can) **[override or adjust later]**.

Rules

- Full sentences.
- Explains scope, impact, or timing.

Examples

- **Enable secure access to cloud consoles**
- *Sets the default theme for all users. They can change it later in their personal settings.*
- *Dark mode is not available on all pages yet.*

Steppers

Pattern:

[Verb] [object]

Example

1. Select capabilities
2. Specify account
3. Deploy & scan

G. First-time / onboarding patterns

Purpose

Reduce uncertainty, establish momentum, and reassure users.

Header (What)

Pattern:

Welcome to [product / area]

Body (So what)

Pattern:

(We'll) **[do X]** so that **[outcome]**.

(Optional reassurance) (You can) **[change / add / undo later]**.

CTA (What next)

Pattern:

[Single forward action]

Examples

- **Welcome to Codename**
- *Just provide a few details about your roles and organization.*

Next

- **Set up your first cloud discovery**
You can add other cloud environments and entity types later.
 - **Discovery setup is complete**
(Provide next-step navigation)
-

Syntax & casing

- **Sentence case default.** Use Title Case only for true product names.
- **Labels = nouns. Descriptions = verbs.**
- Minimize hyphens; prefer clear two-word phrases over compound forms.

UI element lexicon (naming)

Use these terms consistently in UI text and reviews: - **dialog** (not “dialog box”). - **dropdown list** (avoid hyphens). - **field** (not “box”). - **option** (for radio buttons). - **toggle button** → verbs **enable/disable** (avoid “on/off” unless label cannot change). - **navigation pane** (lowercase; links in **bold**; don’t add the word *link*). - **more options** (three dots); **collapsed menu** (three lines). Avoid “hamburger/kebab”. - **service picker** (9-dot grid). - **click / tap / select**: We only tell the user to click when they are taking an action on another screen. Instead, we just state the action. default to **click** cross-surface; use **tap** when exclusively mobile.

Links vs Buttons (perspective + use)

- **Buttons**: commit or change state now (first-person intent in imperative form).
 - **Links**: navigate or learn without committing. Prefer **Take me there** for problem-solving jumps; reserve **Learn more** for deep guidance.
 - Add the external-link icon when leaving product context and open external targets in a new tab/window.
 - **Don’t use “here”** as link text. Link the subject: **Learn more about MFA**.
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Terminology & glossary discipline

- We’ll resolve term drift with a living **glossary** (say/avoid, examples).
 - Decide by **context & level** (e.g., **app** in UI labels; **application** in legal/ops).
 - **Language uniformity**: choose and document page-level usage (**web app / app / application**) and **stay consistent within a page**; defer disputes to the glossary.
 - Keep page-internal usage **consistent**; lighten terminology down the page (formal → friendly).
 - **Capabilities vs products**: write about **capabilities** generically, lowercase, and avoid treating them as entities; prefer tasks/outcomes.
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Bridge: Tech-writing → Microcopy (what carries over)

Source: CyberArk Technical Writing rules. This section distills only what's relevant to UI microcopy. For the full lists and edge cases, refer to **Golden rules of technical writing at CyberArk** (language, punctuation, abbreviations, numbers, terminology) and related sub-sections in the Tech Writing guide.

Language & tone

- **American English.**
- **Second person** (“you”), not “the user”.
- **Active voice; present tense.** Avoid future. Use passive only for the listed exceptions.
- **Positive, plain language.** No pompous/formal; avoid vague words and superlatives.
- **Bias-free & inclusive.** Use allowlist/denylist; gender-neutral “they”.
- **No Latin** (e.g., i.e.). Prefer plain English (“for example”, “that is”).
- **Avoid “please note”.** However, **“Please try again” is acceptable**

Consistency & terminology

- **Define once; use consistently.** Defer disputes to the **Glossary**; settle page-local usage.
- **Casing:** sentence case everywhere except proper names. Avoid mid-sentence caps.
- **Hyphens:** use for compound adjectives before a noun; minimize elsewhere.
- **Oxford comma.**
- **Numbers:** microcopy may use numerals <10 when space/scanability benefits (docs may differ).

Scannability (UI-tuned)

- Short sentences; break up long lines.
- Prefer **tables / key-pairs** over long bullets where users must compare values.
- Keep **labels = nouns; descriptions = verbs** (aligns with doc “task” focus).

Cross-surface rules we keep (UI ↔ Docs)

- **Don't document obvious UI results** → in UI, don't say what is visible; use affordances.
- **One best path** (avoid “or” soup) → mirrors our CTA discipline.
- **Linking language** → prefer **“See ...”**, avoid **“here”**. External links open in new tab; in product, use **Take me there** when navigation is the fix.
- **“One or more”** phrasing for selectable items; avoid parenthetical plurals (e.g., file(s)).

Where UI diverges (callouts)

- **Headings/Titles:** Docs prefer imperative H1s (“Configure X”). In UI, our **Pages** use noun titles + benefit subheaders; **Dialogs** use verb titles.
- **Gerunds:** Avoid in headings both places; OK in body only if clarity improves.
- **Dates/Times:** Docs use “13 February, 2022”. UI follows product locale; keep ISO only in dev/admin views.
- **Mobile verbs:** Docs distinguish **tap/select/click**. In UI strings we default to **click** cross-surface; use **tap** when exclusively mobile.

Referencing pages (docs vs UI)

- **Docs:** It's acceptable to write “On the **Connect cloud environments** page, click ...”.

- **UI microcopy:** Prefer **breadcrumbs** and concise **Page titles**; avoid repeating page names inside instructional strings. Use **links/CTAs** that describe the action (e.g., **Take me there, Open Connect cloud environments**) instead of “On the X page...”.

Process & review (text is part of design)

- **Get text in early** (Axure, Figma, Working doc). No lorem ipsum in reviewed screens.
- **Traceability:** capture **Before/After** with rationale.
- **Statuses:** In progress → Reviewed by TW → Done → Dev.
- **QA visibility:** define who validates microcopy in staging; keep links to proof states.

Real text at wireframe saves cycles. Keep the one-pager at hand in reviews; use Before/After captures to build traceability and training examples.

Information Placement & Progressive Guidance

CyberArk interfaces are written for experienced admins who prioritize speed and clarity. **Primary UI text (titles, tile titles, primary subheaders)** communicates only what is needed to act: *what this is* and *what it enables*. Avoid definitions and background in primary surfaces. If a user must understand something to proceed, include a **single-line secondary explanation** or **inline helper text**. If understanding is optional, defer it to a tooltip or modal. This keeps the interface fast for experts while remaining legible to users encountering a concept for the first time.

Guidance scales outward using **progressive disclosure**: Use **tooltips** for short clarifications (acronyms, thresholds, consequences). Use **modals or dialogs** when the user’s action depends on understanding risk, impact, or prerequisites. Use **welcome dialogs and onboarding overlays** only to establish orientation: *what this area is for, what success looks like, and what to do first*. Break onboarding into steps only when actions are sequential; otherwise, keep it to a single screen with clear exits. Assume users may skip—content should still be discoverable later through tooltips, help icons, or AI.

When information exceeds the UI’s scope, guide users **off the page intentionally**. Use **Learn more** as a standardized, low-cognitive-load link to reference documentation or conceptual depth. Use **verb-based links** (e.g., *Download template, View audit log*) only when the action itself is the goal, and mark external destinations clearly. The global help icon and Cora AI act as **last-mile support**: they answer “How do I...?” and “Why am I seeing this?” without interrupting flow. Prefer in-product guidance first; escalate outward only when the user’s intent shifts from doing to learning.